wounded in an attack in the United States in August 2022.) From *The Satanic Verses*, attention has thus shifted to the Muslim community in Europe, to their apparently awkward religion being at odds with the liberal values of British and other European cultures: similarly, Turkish culture in West Germany and Algerian in France were increasingly seen as problematic.[112]

It is significant that these developments (accidentally) coincided with the fall of the Iron Curtain and the 'return' of former European communist countries to the imagined community of 'Europe'. Namely, this coincidence only further strengthened Western confidence both towards non-European immigrants as well as now former 'Eastern' Europeans. The war in what was Yugoslavia, with its ethnic and religious undertones, also aroused a degree of cultural fear.

The issue of the (in)compatible culture of European Muslims (and other non-Western people) thus called into question the hitherto considerable support for the concept of multiculturalism. There is certainly some confusion as to the meaning of this word: it could be simply a factual description of the existence of different cultural communities in a society, or of government policies to address related issues. Or, as some would claim, an ideology that would see an inherent moral quality in the mere existence of such a community and therefore something that needs to be actively encouraged.

But whatever the meaning, multiculturalism was soon to be pronounced dead in Europe. Chancellor Merkel in 2010 stated, with some regret, that multiculturalism 'failed utterly' and that it was an illusion to believe that the Germans and foreign workers could 'live happily side by side', although she also recognised that Islam was now a part of German culture.[113]

The situation was similar in other countries. When I came to the Netherlands as a diplomat in 2009, the country had already had a difficult migration experience and had more or less lost faith in multiculturalism. In November 2004, a young Muslim man in Amsterdam brutally murdered a Dutch film director Theo van Gogh (coincidentally related to the famous painter), in revenge for van Gogh's film, critical of Islam and made in collaboration with Ayaan Hersi Ali, a Somali-born Dutch who became an atheist and a vocal critic of Islam. In his book *Murder in Amsterdam*, Dutch historian and writer Ian Buruma explored the reasons that led to such a